



Sarah nagbenta ng mga bag, lipat-bahay sa bagong taon! P.3

Semis series itatakda ng Tropang 5G, E-Painters P.4

VOICES THAT CANNOT BE SILENCED: PAPI'S STAND AGAINST FAKE NEWS AND CORRUPTION

BALIWAG, Bulacan — Philippine journalism. Long before the speeches began and the applause filled the halls, a quiet realization settled over the delegates of the 29th National Press Congress: In an age drowning in misinformation, their calling has never been more vital.

Held on December 3–4, 2025 at The Greenery in Baliwag, Bulacan, this year’s gathering of the Publishers Association of the Philippines, Inc. (PAPI) was more than an annual event—it was a reunion of truth-seekers, a summit of storytellers, and a testament to the enduring power of

Philippine journalism. The theme, “Unmasking Deception: The Role of Investigative Media in Exposing Fake News and Corruption,” set the tone for a congress that was both reflective and forward-looking. A Ceremony That Set the Stage Day 1 opened with the solemn Entry of Colors by Bulacan State University, followed by a heartfelt doxology by Pastor Elpedio B. Soriano Jr. As the AVP played the National Anthem and the PAPI Hymn, delegates paused—perhaps remembering the honor and responsibility of



DOST CAR leads the benchmarking in Santa Rosa City to advance smart and sustainable initiatives



Through the coordination of DOST-CALABARZON, the Local Government Unit (LGU) of the City of Santa Rosa hosted a successful benchmarking activity on December 3, 2025. The event was attended by officials and representatives from various DOST regional and provincial offices. This activity is a key component of the project “Empowering Commu-

DOST REGION 2 CHAMPIONS YOUTH ENGAGEMENT AND GENDER ADVOCACY IN VAWC CAMPAIGN EVENT



As part of the nationwide 18-Day Campaign to End Violence Against Women and Children (VAWC), the Department of Science and Technology Region 02 successfully conducted its advocacy program “Mentoring Change: MOVE Forward to End Violence Against Women” on December 4, 2025, at the DOST R02 Conference Room. The event gathered a diverse audience—including representatives from partner agencies, DOST R02 staff, and a strong delegation of on-the-job trainees (OJTs) and immersion students from across Cagayan—highlighting the crucial role of youth partic-

REVISED BULACAN
TOURISM CODE.



Governor Daniel R. Fernando and Vice Gov. Alexis C. Castro present an enlarged copy of the Provincial Ordinance No. 126-2025 or “An ordinance revising the Provincial Ordinance No. 2012-04, establishing the Tourism Code of Bulacan” to the attendees of the Monday Flag Ceremony held at the Bulacan Capitol Gymnasium, City of Malolos, Bulacan yesterday. Also in the photo are (from left) Board Members Michael Aquino, Fortunato Angeles, and Richard Roque, Provincial Administrator Antonia V. Constantino, Board Romina Fermin, and Provincial History, Arts, Culture, and Tourism Office-Tourism Division Head Limuel Jan Lobederio.

Iprinisinta nina Gobernador Daniel R. Fernando at Bise Gob. Alexis C. Castro ang pinalaking sipi ng Provincial Ordinance No. 126-2025 o “An ordinance revising the Provincial Ordinance No. 2012-04, establishing the Tourism Code of Bulacan” sa mga dumalo ng Lingguhang Pagtataas ng Watawat sa Bulacan Capitol Gymnasium, Lung-sod ng Malolos, Bulacan kahapon. Makikita rin sa larawan sina (mula kaliwa) mga Bokal Michael Aquino, Fortunato Angeles, at Richard Roque, Panlalawigang Tagapangasiwa Antonia V. Constantino, Bokal Romina Fermin, at Provincial History, Arts, Culture, and Tourism Office-Tourism Division Head Limuel Jan Lobederio.

VOICES THAT CANNOT BE
SILENCED... FROM PAGE 1



ity behind their work.

Congress Director Alma Ochotorena welcomed the participants, but the moment grew more emotional when the assembly turned its attention to a man whose legacy continues to guide PAPI.

A Tribute to a Fallen Pillar of Journalism During the opening program, PAPI members and guests offered a heartfelt tribute and prayer for the late PAPI Chairman Emeritus Juan P. Dayang, one of the country’s most respected journalists and a towering figure in community media.

His immense contribution, wisdom, and decades-long dedication to Philippine journalism were remembered in solemn reflection. Many delegates bowed their heads, acknowledging the profound void left by his passing—and the responsibility of continuing the work he championed.

It was a moment that anchored the congress in gratitude and purpose, reminding every journalist in the room that they stand on the shoulders of pioneers who fought tirelessly for truth.

Leadership, Commitment, and a Keynote That Hit Home Following the tribute, a welcome message from Baliwag City Mayor Sonia Vi-

ceo-Estrella—delivered through her official representative—affirmed the city’s support for responsible journalism.

PAPI Chairman for Media Affairs Nelson S. Santos then took delegates through PAPI’s decades-long commitment to defending press freedom. When Jason Phillip V. Gutierrez of The New York Times and Asia Times took the stage for the keynote address, he spoke candidly about disinformation’s growing sophistication and the danger it poses to truth, democracy, and journalists themselves.

Learning, Sharing, and Confronting the Digital Battlefield Lively open forums reflected a common battle cry from journalists across Luzon, Visayas, and Mindanao: The fight against misinformation must be collective, continuous, and courageous.

Governor’s Night: A Celebration of Unity and Diversity Delegates later returned dressed in striking United Nations-themed attire for Governor’s Night—a celebration of cultural pride and journalistic solidarity.

PAPI President Rebecca Velasquez opened the ceremony followed by Vice President for Mindanao Anila Anne Acosta who intro-

duced the guest of honor Governor Daniel R. Fernando, though unable to attend in person, Governor Daniel R. Fernando sent his administrator to deliver a message praising the press as “guardian pillars of truth.”

Media leaders, government officials, and innovators echoed their support throughout the night. A major highlight was the awarding of ₱30,000 in raffle prizes and in-kind items, administered by PAPI Vice President for Visayas, Ms. Giecel Toriano-Albar. Donations from supporters across the country showcased how far the community of journalism advocates extends.

Day 2: Tourism, Technology, and a Nation’s Story

The second day opened with a journey through Bulacan’s cultural soul, guided by May Arlene DG. Torres, who presented the province’s heritage-rich landmarks, historic sites, and preservation efforts.

This was followed by a powerful Zoom lecture by Professor Jeremiah Opiniano, PhD, titled “Combating Misinformation in Advancing Digital Literacy.” His sharp insights mapped the evolving digital battlefield and prepared journalists for the challenges ahead. Closing Remarks were

delivered by PAPI Executive Vice President Ian Israel D. Junio who thanked the delegates, speakers, and partner institutions for their support and reaffirmed the organizations commitment to strengthening ethical and investigative journalism nationwide.

Heritage, Innovation, and a Dinner to Remember

Delegates then visited historic Malolos sites before proceeding to Bauertek Pharmaceutical Technologies, where Dr. Richard Nixon Gomez showcased Filipino innovation at its best.

The congress concluded with a heartwarming Christmas boodle fight dinner, also hosted by Dr Richard Gomez— an evening of fellowship, laughter and renewed commitment to the profession.

A Congress That Reignited Purpose

As delegates traveled back to their respective provinces, they carried renewed conviction -- and the memory of a tribute a fallen giant whose legacy continues to illuminate the path forward. Because in the age of deception, the Filipino journalist’s mission remains clear; To seek truth, expose corruption and never allow misinformation to prevail. --- G.I.E.C.E.L AN-PAPI VP-VISAYAS

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DOST CAR leads the benchmarking in Santa Rosa City... Mula pahina 1



nities through SMART Roadmaps and Technologies,” spearheaded by DOST-CAR. Its primary goal is to benchmark progressive cities across the country, with the City of Santa Rosa in Laguna recognized as a leading example. The event served as a vital platform for sharing best practices in implementing smart and sustainable community initiatives, including programs on digital transformation and smart governance efforts. Site Tour and Best Practice Sharing The benchmarking delegation conducted a comprehensive site tour to observe Santa Rosa's innovative projects firsthand: 1. Water Testing Laboratory and Pyrolysis Facility: The tour commenced here, where Engr. Maria Amor Salandanan, City Environment and Natural Resources Of-

ficer, provided an in-depth discussion on the city's innovative waste management and circular economy projects. 2. Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Office (DRRMO): Mr. Antonio Z. Lu, City DRRMO Operations Manager, guided the delegation, showcasing Santa Rosa's advanced disaster preparedness and response capabilities. This included facilities, equipment, vehicles, the AI-powered traffic monitoring system, incident response mechanisms, and sophisticated weather monitoring approaches. 3. Santa Rosa City Hall and IT Room: The third stop focused on digital governance. Key information systems supporting internal business operations and health-related programs were presented, followed by a brief tour of the IT Room and the City Health Office.

The event concluded with a courtesy visit to the City Mayor's Office, where the delegation was graciously received by Honorable Arlene Arcillas. The City of Santa Rosa is one of the pioneer smart cities in the country and was recently recognized in various categories of DOST's Smart and Sustainable Communities Award during the 2025 National Science, Technology, and Innovation Week (NSTW) held in Laoag City last November 21, 2025. Among the seven distinguished awards received by the LGU are: In the Human Well-Being Pillar • Quick Response: Saffer Santa Rosa (Level 2) • Santa Rosa Book and Ride: Free Toyota Community Shuttle (Level 3) Wealth Protection Pillar • Increasing Santa Rosa City's Resilience Through Disaster Pre-

paredness (Level 2) • Assistance of the Santa Rosa Manpower Training Center in the Employment of Graduate Students (Level 2) • Santa Rosa e-Recruit: Digitalizing Local Employment Matching and Services (Level 3) • Santa Rosa Central Command Center (SRCCC) (Level 3) • Sustained Nourishment: A Collaborative Feeding Initiative with the City of Santa Rosa (Level 3) Santa Rosa City, through the technical assistance of DOST-CALABARZON, continues to reinforce its commitment to serving as a model smart city—one that actively embraces and employs Science, Technology, and Innovation (STI) to sustain and elevate its standard of public service. For S&T-related contents, follow DOST C A L A B A R Z O N . oOo

DOST REGION 2 CHAMPIONS YOUTH ENGAGEMENT... FROM PAGE 1

ipation in advancing gender-sensitive communities. DOST R02 Regional Director Dr. Virginia G. Bilgera opened the program with welcome remarks and an inspirational message, reaffirming the agency's firm commitment to promoting a safer, more inclusive society for women and children. She highlighted the critical responsibility of government institutions, communities, and especially the youth in creating proactive environments that prevent violence before it begins. The program featured two compelling lectures from expert resource speakers who shed light on the cultural and institutional dimensions of gender-based violence. Dr. Trician Jan Taguba-Villarosa delivered a medical perspective in her talk titled “Promoting Healthy Masculinity”, exploring how gender norms shape behavior and how redefining masculinity can contribute to reducing violence against women. Her insights emphasized the need for compassionate, non-violent expressions of manhood and early intervention through education and awareness. Adding a law enforcement perspective, Police Staff Sergeant Mary Jane G. de Obieta of PNP Region 2 presented the Philippine National Police's best practices under MOVE PH (Men Opposed to Violence Everywhere). Her presentation, “Champi-

oning MEN's Involvement in Ending VAW,” showcased successful grassroots programs that position men as advocates and protectors in the campaign to end VAWC. An open forum encouraged interactive participation, with students actively raising questions and sharing reflections on the importance of gender respect, safe spaces, and community solidarity. Their voices echoed a growing movement of youth who are ready to be changemakers in the fight against gender-based violence. The event culminated in a Pledge of Commitment, with all attendees affirming their shared dedication to ending VAWC. Certificates of participation were awarded, acknowledging the valuable contributions of each participant. By convening this forum, DOST Region 2 reaffirmed its role not only as a scientific and technological agency but as a community advocate for gender justice and youth empowerment. The initiative also strengthened the narrative that VAWC prevention is a collective responsibility—one that requires the collaboration of institutions, families, and especially the younger generation. As the 18-Day Campaign continues across the country, DOST 2's program stands as a powerful reminder: Ending violence starts with education, engagement, and empowered voices—especially those of the youth.

SHOWBLITZ By Charlene Mae

Sarah nagbenta ng mga bag, lipat-bahay sa bagong taon!



Bagong taon, bagong bahay ngayong 2026 si Sarah Lahbati. At ipinasilip niya ang ilang bahagi nito kasama ang designer. Aniya sa caption: “new year, new home. excited to be working with @iamurvitaminc on designing our new space. looking forward to collaborating with amazing home builders and home brands along the way.”

Kaya pala nag-a-unload siya ng ibang mga kagamitan. ‘Yung ibang luxury items niya ay ipinabenta ni Sarah like bags at ang ibang mga kagamitan naman ng anak nila ni Richard Gutierrez ay idinonate niya sa orphanage. Wala lang itong nabanggit kung owned or rented ang nasabing bahay na kanilang lilipatan. oOo

SPORTS NEWS

TNT nakauna sa Meralco



MANILA, Philippines — Binura ng Talk ‘N Text ang 21-puntos na bentahe ng Meralco upang maitakas ang 100-95 panalo sa Game 1 ng PBA Season 50 Philippine Cup semifinals kahapon sa Smart Araneta Coliseum.

Unti-unting tinapayas ng Tropang 5G ang higanteng lamang ng Bolts na tinuldukan ng 14-6 panapos na bomba tungo sa 1-0 kartada sa kanilang best-of-seven Final Four series.

Humataw ng 28 puntos, 7 rebounds at 2 assists si Calvin Oftana upang trangkuhan ang TNT sa comeback win mula sa maalat na simula matapos kalawangin sa matagal na break dahil sa Bagong Taon at madaling pagpasok nila sa semis.

Nakatulong niya sina Rey Nambatac at Roger Pogoy na may 17 at 16

puntos, ayon sa pagkakasunod habang may double-double na 14 puntos at 10 rebounds sahog pa ang 1 tapal si Brandon Ganuelas-Rosser.

Nag-ambag din ng 9, 8 at 6 puntos sina Jordan Heading, Kelly Williams at Glenn Khobuntin, ayon sa pagkakasunod, para sa mga tropa ni coach Chot Reyes.

“Credits to Meralco for coming out with really a good game plan. In the end, I just told them to go back to fundamentals and defend the point of attack better but we have to do a better job in Game 2 to defend that way,” ani Reyes.

Kontra sa Meralco sakay ng 2 sunod na panalo sa quarterfinals, natulog pa sa pansitan

ang Tropang 5G nang maiwan sa hanggang 31-52 at hanggang sa 46-62 sa halftime.

Subalit pinatunayan ng TNT ang kalibre nito bilang runner-up ng Season 49 All-Filipino tourney nang unti-unting ubusin ang kuryente ng Meralco hanggang sa makalapit sa 86-89 sa huling 5 minuto. Doon na naghasik ng lagim ang Tropang 5G sa bandera ni Oftana na sinalpak ang and-one basket para maibigay sa koponan ang manibela sa unang pagkakataon, 94-91, sa huling 2:57 ng laro.

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